Upbound – Senior Product Marketing Manager

Dear Upbound team,

Building a market for a product before anyone has named its category is work I've already done. Modelplane, the product Upbound launched in June, needs that work before someone else names its category.

Your founder Bassam Tabbara put the problem as "inference doesn't stay on one cluster." Companies that run open-weight AI models at scale end up running them across many clusters, and they need one place to manage them. Upbound has done this once already. With Crossplane, its open-source project, it named the "cloud-native control plane" before analysts had a category for it.

At Reform, a form and onboarding platform built for developers, I repositioned the product for buyers who had no fixed picture of the category. I rebuilt the messaging around the people we were selling to. Trial activation rose 34% and trial-to-paid conversion rose 21%. At Upbound, that is the work of turning "fleet-level AI inference management" into a claim a buyer understands on first read.

At Hank Robotics, an AI drone and robotics company, I learned the category from scratch and built the positioning, ideal customer profile and messaging. Marketing qualified leads grew 1,900% in three months. Modelplane's buyers are infrastructure engineers, so the marketing has to get the product right from the first week.

I also run technical infrastructure myself. I host my own n8n workflow automation server on a Google Cloud virtual machine with Docker and Traefik. I also use Claude Code and custom agents for prospecting, lifecycle email and campaign reporting. I know from my own setup what it takes to run and maintain this kind of infrastructure.

The hardest part of this role is the line between the Crossplane community and the paid product. More than 1,000 organizations use Crossplane. They need a clear account of what Modelplane adds, written so the community never feels like a sales funnel. I've worked in product-led companies where the community member and the enterprise buyer were often the same person, so I know the content has to stay useful to both.

In my first 90 days I'd write the commercial positioning document and build content that connects community users to the paid product. I'd also build a competitive comparison and brief industry analysts on "fleet-level AI inference management" as a category. My strategy hypothesis lays this out, and I'd welcome the chance to talk it through.

James Praise

P.S. I've created a portfolio focused on this role at jamespraise.xyz/work/upbound.